



LOOKING FOR CLOSURE

Institutes which were set up to reshape the destiny of free India are either languishing for want of attention or have become political handmaidens

Dinosaur organisations in a post-modern world, rusty steam engines in the era of bullet trains. Some institutions don't wear their age well, undone by changes in government or inept officials. A quick run down of 20 institutions that need to be locked up, or just given a long vacation.

Sports Authority of India: Set up in 1984, it has an annual budget of over Rs 170 crore, a staff strength of close to 4,000 and consumes two-thirds of the sports budget in salaries.

Does it have a core competence? No. Indian sport doesn't need a link between the sports ministry and federations. Indeed, it doesn't need a sports ministry.

National Security Council: Formed after Pokhran II in 1998 and headed by the prime minister, it was intended to be the Government's one-stop strategic powerhouse in these dangerous times.

Will it be missed? Yes. But only by retired bureaucrats looking for plum posts.

Lalit Kala Akademi: Meant to promote visual arts, the organisation has been plagued by controversy in its 54 years, whether for financial irregularities or for misuse of discretionary powers by its members.

Do we need it? No. The Government of the day has to find some other way to spend its over Rs 10-crore budget.

Bharat Bhavan: Its new trust headed by Pandit Jasraj says it's apolitical, but the multi-arts complex, established in Bhopal in the early '80s with an annual budget of Rs 1.5 crore, is better known as a battleground between the Congress and BJP.

What's the option? Either a massive dose of autonomy or a quick

reading of the epitaph.

Indian Institute of Advanced Study: Its primary objective was to provide an environment suitable for academic research and "deep reflection of the human condition", but over the years it has become a refuge for mediocrity, better known for the legal wrangling over its historic location (it was the Shimla home of the Viceroy) than its academic work.

Should it stay? No. Despite an annual budget of Rs 7 crore and 40 three-year fellowships, it has failed to build a network with institutions of higher learning in India and abroad.

Indian Council of World Affairs: Once one of Jawaharlal Nehru's favourite haunts, and host to a stream of world leaders, it has degenerated into a venue for bawdy Punjabi plays.

Can it be rescued? In 2001, it was declared an institution of national importance and it is now chaired by the vice-president, but 65 years on, it is still nowhere close to becoming the big daddy of Indian think tanks.

Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts: Set up in 1987 with a Rs 50-crore corpus, it has witnessed several tugs-of-war, whether between the Congress and the NDA Government or over the failure to construct more than one of the planned eight buildings despite Rs 89 lakh being spent on the project.

What can be done? Rent it out.

The Indian Institute of Advanced Study has no permanent faculty but it has an excellent research library.